GEC 2026 – English

Grade 9 · Study Notes based on the GEC demarcation (English HL & FAL)
Comprehension · Visual Literacy · Language Structures and Conventions · Vocabulary

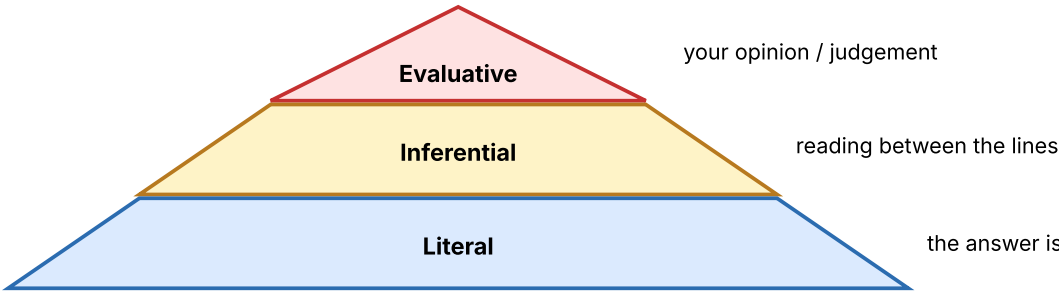
Contents

1. **Comprehension** – comprehension skills and inference · figurative language · manipulative language · writer's intention and tone · summary writing
2. **Visual literacy** – cartoons and advertisements · visual techniques and their effects · humour and message
3. **Language structures and conventions** – parts of speech · sentence types · phrases and clauses · conjunctions · tenses · active and passive voice · direct and indirect speech · punctuation · spelling and plurals
4. **Vocabulary** – synonyms · prefixes and suffixes · homophones and homonyms · ambiguity, clichés and redundancy · connotation and denotation · formal and informal language · abbreviations

1. Comprehension

1.1 Comprehension skills

Comprehension means **understanding** a text – not only what it says, but also what it **means** and what the writer **wants**. Questions test understanding on three levels:



The three levels of comprehension questions

Level	What it asks	Question words	How to answer
Literal	Facts stated **directly** in the text	Who? What? When? Where? Name... List... Quote...	Find the answer in the text. "Quote" = copy the exact words in **inverted commas**.
Inferential	What is **suggested / implied** but not said directly	Why? What does this suggest? What can you infer? Explain...	Use clues from the text + your own reasoning; refer to the text.
Evaluative	Your **opinion or judgement** about the text, with reasons	Do you agree? Is this effective? Discuss... Comment on...	Give your view (yes / no) and **support it** with evidence from the text.

Instruction words

Word	What you must do
Quote	Copy the exact word(s) from the text in inverted commas.
Identify / Name / State	Give a short answer – no explanation needed.
Explain / Why	Give reasons in your own words – show that you understand.
Discuss / Comment	Look at different sides, give your view and support it.
In your own words	Do **not** copy from the text; rephrase.
Give ONE word	Only one word – more words lose the mark.
True or False + reason	Say True/False and quote or give the evidence.

1.2 Inference

To **infer** is to work out something the writer does **not** say directly, using **clues** in the text and your own knowledge. An **inference** is a logical conclusion.

> **Clues + what I know = inference**
> *"Thabo slammed the door, threw his bag on the floor and stormed to his room."*
> Clues: *slammed, threw, stormed* → what I know: people do this when upset → **Inference: Thabo is angry.**

Text	Inference
The streets were wet and people were shaking their umbrellas as they came inside.	It has been raining.
She checked her watch for the fifth time and tapped her foot.	She is impatient / waiting for someone who is late.
The old man's hands were rough and covered in calluses.	He has done hard physical work all his life.

1.3 Figurative language

Literal language means exactly what it says. **Figurative** language uses words in an **imaginative**, non-literal way to create a picture, add emphasis or make the writing more interesting. When asked about a figure of speech, **name it**, **explain what is compared/meant**, and give its **effect**.

Figure of speech	Meaning	Example
Simile	Compares two different things using **"like" or "as"**	*He ran like the wind. · She is as busy as a bee.*
Metaphor	Compares by saying one thing **is** another (no like/as)	*The classroom was a zoo. · Time is money.*
Personification	Gives **human qualities** to a non-human thing	*The wind whispered through the trees.*
Hyperbole	Extreme **exaggeration** for emphasis	*I've told you a million times!*
Understatement	Makes something seem **less** important than it is	*(After a flood destroyed the house) "It's a bit wet in here."*
Alliteration	Repetition of the same **consonant sound** at the start of nearby words	*Peter Piper picked a peck of pickled peppers.*
Assonance	Repetition of **vowel sounds** in nearby words	*The rain in Spain stays mainly in the plain.*
Onomatopoeia	A word that **sounds like** the sound it describes	*buzz, crash, sizzle, bang, hiss*

Oxymoron	Two **opposite words** side by side	*deafening silence, bitter-sweet, act naturally*
Paradox	A statement that seems to contradict itself but contains a truth	*Less is more.*
Antithesis	Opposite ideas placed in a balanced sentence	*Speech is silver, silence is golden.*
Irony	The **opposite** of what is expected or meant	*A fire station burns down.*
Sarcasm	Saying the opposite of what you mean to **mock or hurt**	*"Oh great, another test – I'm so thrilled."*
Pun	A play on words with **two meanings** – used for humour	*I used to be a banker, but I lost interest.*
Euphemism	A mild word for something unpleasant	*He passed away (= died).*
Rhetorical question	A question asked for **effect**, with no answer expected	*Who doesn't want to be happy?*
Symbol	An object that stands for an idea	*a dove = peace; a red rose = love*
Idiom	A fixed expression whose meaning is not literal	*It's raining cats and dogs.* · *Break a leg.*

> **Answering a figurative-language question – example:** *"The classroom was a zoo."*
> **Figure of speech:** metaphor. **Comparison:** the classroom is compared to a zoo. **Effect:** it shows how noisy, wild and out of control the learners were.

1.4 Manipulative language

Manipulative language is language used to **persuade or influence** people to think, feel or act in a certain way – often without them noticing. It is used in advertisements, speeches, politics and the media.

Technique	How it works	Example
Emotive language	Words chosen to cause strong **feelings** (pity, fear, anger, excitement)	*Innocent, helpless puppies are dying alone in the cold.*
Loaded words	Words with strong positive or negative connotations	*"thug" vs "young man"; "bargain" vs "cheap"*
Bias	Showing only **one side** of a story; unfair favour or prejudice	*A report that only quotes people who support the mayor.*
Bandwagon	"Everyone is doing it – join them"	*Join the millions who already drink FizzUp!*

Testimonial / celebrity endorsement	A famous or trusted person recommends it	*A famous rugby player says: "I only wear SpeedX boots."*
Expert opinion / statistics	Facts, numbers or "experts" make it sound reliable	*9 out of 10 dentists recommend...*
Glittering generalities	Vague, positive words with no real meaning	*the best, amazing, new and improved, natural*
Fear appeal	Scares people into acting	*Don't let germs harm your family – use KillGerm.*
Flattery	Praises the reader	*Because you deserve the best.*
Plain folks	"I'm just an ordinary person like you"	*A politician eating vetkoek at a taxi rank.*
Name-calling	Negative labels for an opponent	*My opponent is a liar and a failure.*
Repetition	Repeating a word / slogan so it sticks	*Buy now! Buy today! Buy SuperSnack!*
Rhetorical questions	Make the reader agree in their mind	*Don't you want whiter teeth?*
Exaggeration / superlatives	Overstates the product's qualities	*The world's best burger!*
Direct address ("you")	Speaks to the reader personally	*You can make a difference.*
Urgency / scarcity	Pressure to act fast	*Limited stock! Offer ends Friday!*

Fact vs opinion: a **fact** can be proved (*The shop opens at 08:00.*); an **opinion** is a personal view (*It is the best shop in town.*). Manipulative texts often present opinions as if they were facts.

1.5 Writer's intention (purpose) and tone

The **writer's intention** is **why** the text was written. The **tone** is the writer's **attitude or feeling** towards the topic or reader, shown through word choice, punctuation and style. (**Mood** is the feeling the text creates in the **reader**.)

Intention	Clues
To **inform**	Facts, statistics, neutral language (news reports, textbooks)
To **persuade**	Manipulative language, opinions, "you", commands (adverts, speeches)
To **entertain**	Story, humour, description (stories, cartoons)
To **instruct**	Numbered steps, commands (recipes, manuals)

To **criticise / warn / raise awareness**	Negative or urgent words, a problem is highlighted

Tone	Meaning	Tone	Meaning
Sarcastic	Mocking, says the opposite	**Humorous**	Funny, light-hearted
Serious	Formal, important	**Critical**	Finding fault
Angry / indignant	Upset about something unfair	**Sympathetic**	Showing understanding and pity
Nostalgic	Longing for the past	**Optimistic**	Hopeful, positive
Pessimistic	Expecting the worst	**Admiring**	Full of praise
Urgent	Something must happen now	**Objective / neutral**	No personal feelings, facts only
Ironic	Says one thing, means another	**Persuasive**	Trying to convince
Concerned / worried	Anxious about a problem	**Disappointed**	Let down

> **Naming a tone:** give **one tone word** (an adjective) and **prove it** with a quotation. *"Oh wonderful, the bus is late again."* → Tone: **sarcastic** – the writer says "wonderful" but clearly means the opposite.

1.6 Summary writing

A **summary** is a **shortened version** of a text that gives only the **main points** in your **own words**.

Steps

1. **Read the instruction carefully:** what topic must you summarise (often only part of the text), how many points, how many words, point form or paragraph?
2. **Read the text** and **underline** only the sentences about the given topic.
3. **Select the main points** – usually one per paragraph (often the topic sentence).
4. **Leave out:** examples, repetition, descriptions (adjectives/adverbs), quotations, figures of speech, statistics and your own opinion.
5. **Rewrite** each point in your **own words**, as a full sentence.
6. **Count the words** and write the number at the end, e.g. *(Words: 78)*. Stay within the limit.

Point form	Paragraph form
Numbered, **full** sentences, one point per sentence: 1. Exercise strengthens the heart. 2. It reduces stress.	One **fluent paragraph** joined with linking words (*firstly, also, furthermore, in addition, finally*). No title unless asked.

Example: *"Sleep is extremely important for teenagers, who are growing quickly. Doctors say that teenagers, like 15-year-old Sipho, need between eight and ten hours of sleep every single night. Without enough sleep, learners struggle to concentrate in class and their marks drop. Sleep also helps the body to fight off illnesses such as colds and flu."*

Summary (point form): 1. Teenagers need 8–10 hours of sleep a night. 2. Too little sleep affects concentration and marks. 3. Sleep helps the body fight illness.

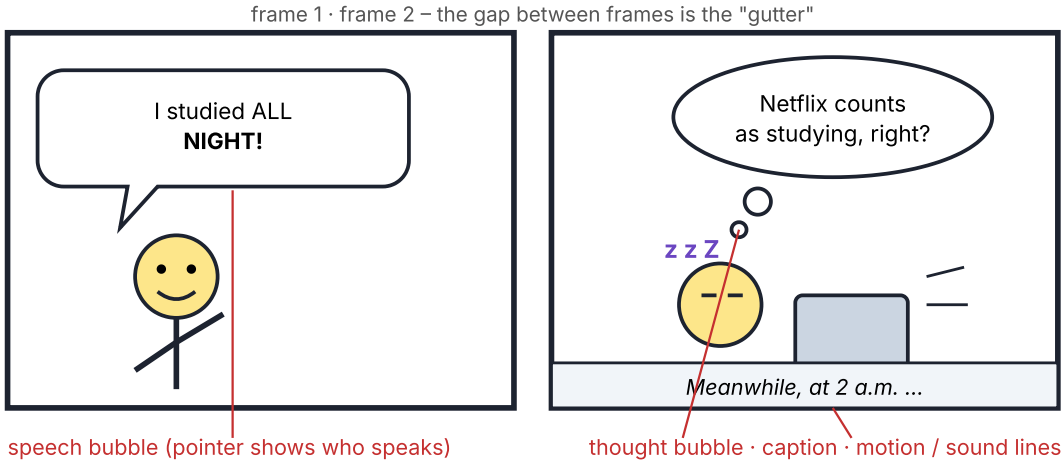
Left out: "extremely", the example of Sipho, "every single night", "such as colds and flu".

2. Visual Literacy

Visual literacy is the ability to "read" pictures: to understand how images, words and design work together to create a **message**. In the exam you get a **cartoon** and/or an **advertisement**.

2.1 Cartoons

A **cartoon** is a drawing (often with words) that is meant to be **funny** and/or to make a **point** (comment or criticise). **Comic strips** tell a short story in several frames; **political / editorial cartoons** comment on current events.



Parts of a comic strip – the humour comes from the contrast between what he says and what he did (irony)

Element	What it shows / effect
Frame (panel)	Each box shows one moment; frames are read left to right.
Speech bubble	Words spoken aloud; the pointer shows the speaker. A **jagged** bubble = shouting/anger; dotted = whispering.
Thought bubble	Cloud with small circles – what a character thinks but doesn't say.
Caption	Box with narration: time, place, background (e.g. "Later that day...").
Font / lettering	**Bold**, CAPITALS or bigger letters = shouting or emphasis; small letters = whispering.
Facial expression	Shows emotions: raised eyebrows = surprise; frown = anger; tears = sadness.
Body language	Posture and gestures: hands on hips = annoyed; slumped = tired / sad; arms up = excitement.
Motion lines / sound effects	Lines show movement; words such as CRASH! or zzz (onomatopoeia) show sound.
Symbols	Light bulb = idea; hearts = love; stars = pain/dizziness; sweat drops = nervousness.

Exaggeration / caricature	Features drawn too big (nose, ears, body) to make fun of a person or make a point.

2.2 Humour and message

Most cartoons have two layers: what makes it **funny**, and the **message** (the point the cartoonist wants to make about people or society).

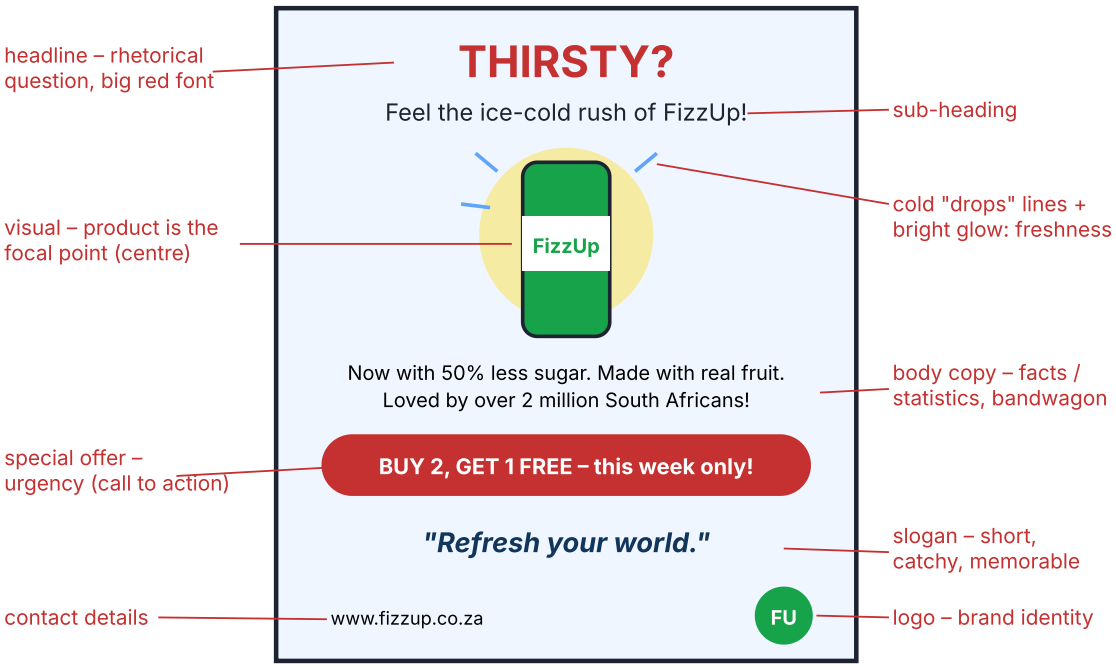
How humour is created	Explanation
Irony / contrast	What happens is the opposite of what is said or expected (he says he studied but watched TV).
Exaggeration	Things are made much bigger or more extreme than in real life.
Pun / play on words	A word with a double meaning.
Surprise ending (punchline)	The last frame turns the story around unexpectedly.
Sarcasm and satire	**Satire** mocks people, politicians or society to criticise them and make us think.
Slapstick	Physical comedy: falling, slipping, being hit.

> **Explaining a cartoon:** say **what you see** (describe), **why it is funny** (name the technique: irony, exaggeration, pun...), and **what the message** is (e.g. "Teenagers often pretend to work hard while they waste time on screens").

2.3 Advertisements

An **advertisement** tries to **persuade** a **target audience** to buy a product, use a service or support an idea. Adverts follow the **AIDA** principle:

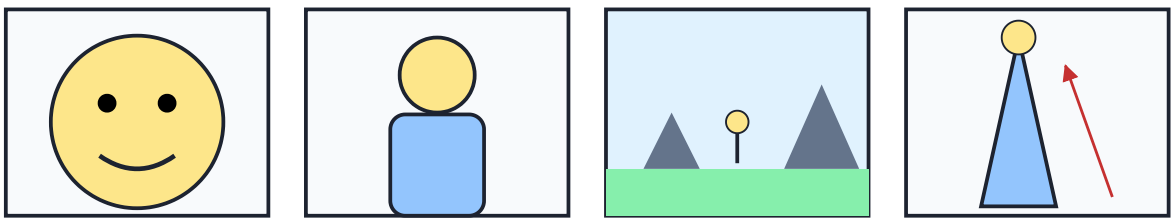
Attention	Catch the eye – bright colours, a big picture, a bold headline.
Interest	Keep the reader looking – interesting information or a question.
Desire	Make them **want** it – show the benefits, happy people, special offers.
Action	Tell them what to do – "Buy now", "Call today", website, QR code.



The parts of a print advertisement (a made-up example)

Element	What it is / purpose
Headline	Large words at the top that grab **attention** – often a question, pun or command.
Visual / image	The main picture; usually the product or happy people using it. Placed as the **focal point**.
Body copy	Smaller text with information and persuasion (facts, benefits, price).
Slogan	A short, catchy phrase linked to the brand, easy to remember (often with alliteration, rhyme or a pun).
Logo	The symbol or design that identifies the brand.
Call to action	Tells the reader what to do: "Order now", "Visit our store".
Target audience	The group the advert is aimed at (age, gender, interests, income) – work it out from the pictures, language and product.

2.4 Visual techniques and their effects



Close-up
face – shows emotion

Medium shot
waist up – body language

Long shot
whole scene – setting

Low angle
looking up – powerful

Camera shots and angles. A high angle (looking down) makes a person look small, weak or vulnerable.

Technique	Effect
Close-up	Focuses on the face or product detail; shows emotion; creates intimacy.
Medium shot	Shows a person from the waist up – body language and some background.
Long shot	Shows the whole person and setting – gives context.
Low angle (looking up)	Subject looks **big, powerful, important**.
High angle (looking down)	Subject looks **small, weak, helpless**.
Eye level	Neutral; the viewer feels equal to the subject.
Colour	Creates mood: red = danger, passion, urgency; blue = calm, trust, cold; green = nature, health; yellow = happiness, energy; black = luxury, sadness; white = purity.
Font	Size, style and colour show importance and personality: bold capitals = urgent; handwriting font = personal; elegant script = luxury.
Layout / placement	The most important item is the **focal point** – usually big, centred or brightly coloured.
Lighting	Bright = happy, positive; dark / shadows = mystery, fear.
Contrast	Opposites placed together (before/after) to highlight a difference.
White space	Empty space makes the advert look clean, modern and focuses attention.

3. Language Structures and Conventions

3.1 Parts of speech

Every word in a sentence has a job. The job is its **part of speech**. The same word can be a different part of speech in another sentence (*I fish on Saturdays* – verb; *The fish swam* – noun).

Part of speech	Job	Examples
Noun	Names a person, place, thing or idea	*girl, Paarl, table, love*
Pronoun	Replaces a noun	*he, she, it, they, mine, who, myself*
Verb	Shows an action or state of being	*run, think, is, have*
Adjective	Describes a noun or pronoun	*tall, red, three, happy*
Adverb	Describes a verb, adjective or other adverb (how, when, where, how often, to what extent)	*quickly, yesterday, here, often, very*
Preposition	Shows the relationship (place, time, direction) between a noun and another word	*in, on, under, after, between, towards*
Conjunction	Joins words, phrases or clauses	*and, but, because, although*
Interjection	Shows sudden emotion	*Wow! Ouch! Hey!*
Article / determiner	Comes before a noun to point it out	*a, an, the, this, those, some*

Wow! The tall boy ran quickly to the shop because he was very hungry.
Wow (interjection) · The (article) · tall (adjective) · boy (noun) · ran (verb) · quickly (adverb) · to (preposition) · the (article) · shop (noun) · because (conjunction) · he (pronoun) · was (verb) · very (adverb) · hungry (adjective)

Kinds of nouns

Kind	Meaning	Examples
Common	General name, no capital letter	*city, dog, teacher*
Proper	Specific name – capital letter	*Cape Town, Rex, Mr Smith, Monday*
Concrete	Can be seen, touched, heard, smelt or tasted	*chair, music, apple*
Abstract	Ideas, feelings, qualities – can't be touched	*honesty, fear, freedom, childhood*
Collective	A name for a group	*a team of players, a flock of sheep, a pride of lions, a swarm of bees*

Countable / uncountable	Can be counted (has a plural) / can't be counted	*book–books / water, advice, furniture*

Kinds of pronouns

Kind	Examples
Personal	*I, you, he, she, it, we, they / me, him, her, us, them*
Possessive	*mine, yours, his, hers, ours, theirs (no apostrophe!)*
Reflexive	*myself, yourself, himself, ourselves, themselves*
Demonstrative	*this, that, these, those (pointing)*
Relative	*who, whom, whose, which, that (start a relative clause)*
Interrogative	*Who? What? Which? Whose? (ask questions)*
Indefinite	*someone, everybody, nothing, anyone, each*

Kinds of verbs

Kind	Meaning	Example
Main (lexical) verb	Carries the meaning	*She **writes** letters.*
Auxiliary (helping) verb	Helps the main verb to form tenses, questions, passive (be, have, do, will, can, must…)	*She **has** written. He **is** running.*
Linking (copula) verb	Links the subject to a description (be, seem, become, appear)	*He **seems** tired.*
Transitive	Has a direct object	*She kicked **the ball**.*
Intransitive	Has no object	*The baby slept.*
Finite / non-finite	Finite has a tense and subject; non-finite = infinitive (to run), participle (running, run) or gerund	*He **runs** (finite) · **to run** (non-finite)*
Gerund	-ing verb used as a noun	***Swimming** is fun.*

Adjectives – degrees of comparison

Positive	Comparative (2 things)	Superlative (3+ things)	Rule
tall	taller	tallest	short words: -er / -est
happy	happier	happiest	y → i
beautiful	more beautiful	most beautiful	long words: more / most

good · bad · many/much · little	better · worse · more · less	best · worst · most · least	irregular

Never use both: ~~more taller~~ → **taller**. Adverbs also compare: *fast – faster – fastest; carefully – more carefully – most carefully; well – better – best*.

Kinds of adverbs

Manner (how?)	Time (when?)	Place (where?)	Frequency (how often?)	Degree (how much?)
slowly, well, loudly	*now, yesterday, soon*	*here, outside, everywhere*	*always, never, often*	*very, too, extremely, almost*

3.2 Sentence types

By purpose (function)

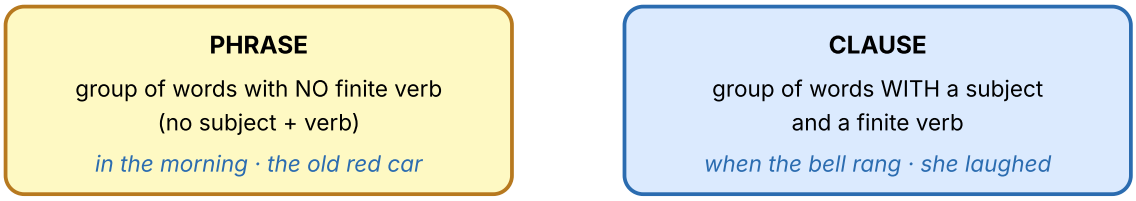
Type	Purpose	Ends with	Example
Declarative (statement)	Gives information	.	*The bus is late.*
Interrogative (question)	Asks something	?	*Is the bus late?*
Imperative (command)	Gives an order, request or instruction	. or !	*Close the door.*
Exclamatory	Shows strong feeling	!	*What a goal that was!*

By structure

Type	Structure	Example
Simple	**One** main clause (one finite verb)	*The dog barked.*
Compound	**Two or more main clauses** joined by a coordinating conjunction (FANBOYS) or a semicolon	*The dog barked* and *the cat ran away.*
Complex	**One main clause + one or more subordinate clauses**	*The cat ran away* *because the dog barked.*
Compound-complex	Two or more main clauses + at least one subordinate clause	*When the dog barked,* *the cat ran away* and *the bird flew off.*

yellow = main clause · blue = subordinate clause

3.3 Phrases and clauses



The difference between a phrase and a clause

Phrases

Phrase	Works like a…	Example
Noun phrase	noun (subject or object)	*The tall girl in the red dress won.*
Adjectival phrase	adjective – describes a noun	*The house on the hill is old.*
Adverbial phrase	adverb – how, when, where	*He arrived after lunch. She spoke with great care.*
Prepositional phrase	starts with a preposition	*under the bed, at school*
Verb phrase	main verb + helping verbs	*She has been working hard.*

Clauses

Clause	What it is	Example
Main (independent) clause	Makes sense on its own – can be a sentence	*I stayed home because I was sick.*
Subordinate (dependent) clause	Does **not** make sense on its own; depends on the main clause. Starts with a subordinating conjunction or relative pronoun.	*I stayed home because I was sick.*
Adjectival (relative) clause	Describes a noun; starts with who, which, that, whose, where	*The boy who won the race is my brother.*
Adverbial clause	Tells how, when, where, why, under what condition	*When the bell rang, we left. (time) · I'll come if it doesn't rain. (condition)*
Noun clause	Acts as a noun (subject or object); often starts with that, what, whether	*I know that you are right. What he said was true.*

3.4 Conjunctions

Kind	Job	Examples

Coordinating (FANBOYS)	Join two **equal** parts (two main clauses, two words) → compound sentence	**F**or, **A**nd, **N**or, **B**ut, **O**r, **Y**et, **S**o *I was tired, **so** I went to bed.*
Subordinating	Start a **subordinate clause** → complex sentence	because, although, when, while, if, unless, since, until, before, after, as soon as, so that, even though ***Although** it rained, we played.*
Correlative	Work in **pairs**	either...or, neither...nor, both...and, not only...but also, whether...or ***Neither** Tom **nor** Sam came.*

Conjunctions show different relationships: **addition** (and, also, furthermore), **contrast** (but, although, however, whereas), **reason** (because, since, as), **result** (so, therefore, consequently), **condition** (if, unless), **time** (when, while, after, before, until).

> **Joining sentences with a given conjunction** – the meaning must stay the same and you may need to change the word order:
> *It was raining. We went to the beach.* (Use: although) → **Although it was raining, we went to the beach.**
> *He studied hard. He passed.* (Use: because) → **He passed because he studied hard.**

However, therefore, moreover are **conjunctive adverbs**, not conjunctions: use a semicolon before and a comma after them when they join two sentences: *It was late; however, we kept working.*

3.5 Tenses

The **tense** of a verb shows **when** an action happens. There are three times (past, present, future), each in four forms:

	Simple	**Continuous (progressive)**	**Perfect**	**Perfect continuous**
Present	I **play** / he **plays**	I **am playing**	I **have played**	I **have been playing**
Past	I **played**	I **was playing**	I **had played**	I **had been playing**
Future	I **will play**	I **will be playing**	I **will have played**	I **will have been playing**

Form	**Use**	**Example**
Simple present	Habits, facts, routines	*The sun rises in the east. She walks to school.*
Present continuous	Happening right now	*I am reading this sentence.*
Present perfect	Happened at an unknown time in the past / still important now	*I have finished my homework.*

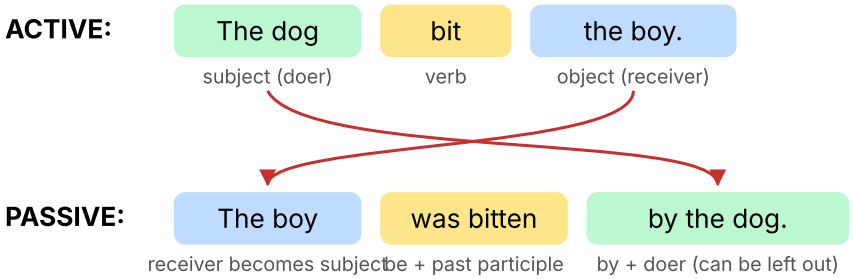
Simple past	Completed at a specific time	*We won the match yesterday.*
Past continuous	In progress in the past, often interrupted	*I was eating when the phone rang.*
Past perfect	Happened **before** another past action	*The train had left when we arrived.*
Simple future	Will happen	*I will call you tomorrow.*
Future perfect	Will be completed before a future time	*By June, I will have finished the book.*

Irregular verbs (learn these)

Present	Past	Past participle	Present	Past	Past participle
be	was/were	been	go	went	gone
begin	began	begun	know	knew	known
break	broke	broken	ride	rode	ridden
bring	brought	brought	rise	rose	risen
choose	chose	chosen	see	saw	seen
do	did	done	sing	sang	sung
drink	drank	drunk	speak	spoke	spoken
eat	ate	eaten	steal	stole	stolen
fly	flew	flown	swim	swam	swum
forget	forgot	forgotten	take	took	taken
give	gave	given	throw	threw	thrown
lie (rest)	lay	lain	write	wrote	written

Concord (subject–verb agreement): a singular subject takes a singular verb, a plural subject a plural verb: *The boy **runs**. The boys **run**.* Watch out: *Each of the boys **is**… · Everyone **has**… · The team **is**… · Neither Tom nor his friends **are**…* (the verb agrees with the nearer subject).

3.6 Active and passive voice



Changing active voice to passive voice: the object and subject swap places

In the **active voice** the subject **does** the action. In the **passive voice** the subject **receives** the action. The passive is used when the doer is unknown or unimportant, or to sound formal and objective (*The window was broken.* · *Mistakes were made.*).

How to change active to passive

1. Make the **object** the new **subject**.
2. Use the correct form of **"to be"** in the **same tense** as the active verb + the **past participle**.
3. Put the old subject after **"by"** (or leave it out). Change pronouns: I → me, he → him, they → them.

Tense	Active	Passive
Simple present	Sam **cleans** the room.	The room **is cleaned** by Sam.
Present continuous	Sam **is cleaning** the room.	The room **is being cleaned** by Sam.
Present perfect	Sam **has cleaned** the room.	The room **has been cleaned** by Sam.
Simple past	Sam **cleaned** the room.	The room **was cleaned** by Sam.
Past continuous	Sam **was cleaning** the room.	The room **was being cleaned** by Sam.
Past perfect	Sam **had cleaned** the room.	The room **had been cleaned** by Sam.
Simple future	Sam **will clean** the room.	The room **will be cleaned** by Sam.
Modal verbs	Sam **must clean** the room.	The room **must be cleaned** by Sam.
Plural object	The teacher **marked** the tests.	The tests **were marked** by the teacher.
Pronouns	**They** invited **me**.	**I** was invited by **them**.
Question	Did **she** write the letter?	Was the letter written by **her**?

Only **transitive** verbs (verbs with an object) can be changed to passive: *The baby slept* has no passive.

3.7 Direct and indirect (reported) speech

Direct speech gives the **exact words** spoken, inside inverted commas. **Indirect (reported) speech reports** what was said, without inverted commas.

> **Direct:** Lerato said, "I am tired today."
> **Indirect:** Lerato said **that she was** tired **that day**.

Rules for changing direct to indirect speech

1. **Remove** the inverted commas; add **"that"** after said/told (for statements).
2. **Change the pronouns** to fit the speaker's point of view: I → he/she; we → they; my → his/her; you → I/me/he/she (depends who is spoken to).
3. **Move the tense one step back** (when the reporting verb is in the past – *said, asked*):

Direct speech	Indirect speech	Example
simple present (am/is/are, play)	simple past (was/were, played)	"I **play**" → he said he **played**
present continuous (is playing)	past continuous (was playing)	"I **am playing**" → he **was playing**
present perfect (has played)	past perfect (had played)	"I **have played**" → he **had played**
simple past (played)	past perfect (had played)	"I **played**" → he **had played**
will / can / may / shall	would / could / might / should	"I **will** come" → he **would** come
must	had to	"You **must** go" → I **had to** go

4. **Change words of time and place** (because the speech is reported later / elsewhere):

Direct	Indirect	Direct	Indirect
now	then	today	that day
here	there	tonight	that night
this / these	that / those	yesterday	the day before / the previous day
ago	before	tomorrow	the next day / the following day
next week	the following week	last week	the week before / the previous week

Questions, commands and requests

Type	Direct	Indirect
Yes/no question	He asked, "**Are you** coming?"	He asked **if / whether I was** coming. (statement word order, no question mark)
Wh- question	She asked, "**Where do you live**?"	She asked **where I lived**.

Command	The teacher said, "**Sit down.**"	The teacher **told / ordered** us **to sit** down.
Negative command	Mom said, "**Don't** be late."	Mom told me **not to be** late.
Request	He said, "**Please help** me."	He **asked / begged** me **to help** him.
Exclamation	She said, "**What a lovely day!**"	She **exclaimed that** it was a lovely day.

If the reporting verb is in the **present** (*says*), the tense does **not** change: *He says, "I am hungry." → He says that he is hungry.* Facts that are always true may also stay in the present: *The teacher said that the earth is round.*

Punctuating direct speech

- Spoken words go inside **inverted commas** and start with a **capital letter**.
- The punctuation mark that ends the spoken words goes **inside** the closing inverted commas.
- Use a **comma** between the speech and the "said" part: *"I'm hungry," said Tom. · Tom said, "I'm hungry."*
- If speech is broken: *"I think," said Tom, "that we should go."* (second part starts with a small letter).
- Start a **new paragraph** each time a new person speaks.

3.8 Punctuation

Mark	Uses	Example
Full stop .	End of a statement or command; after some abbreviations	*I live in Paarl. · etc.*
Question mark ?	End of a direct question (not an indirect question)	*Where are you? · She asked where I was.*
Exclamation mark !	Strong emotion, surprise, commands, interjections	*Watch out! · Wow!*
Comma ,	Separates items in a list; after an introductory word/phrase/clause; before FANBOYS joining two main clauses; around extra information; before direct speech; after "yes/no"; to address someone	*eggs, milk and bread · However, … · When I got home, I slept. · My brother, who is 20, lives in Durban. · Yes, Mr Botha.*
Apostrophe '	**1. Possession**: singular → **'s**; plural ending in s → **s'**; irregular plural → **'s** **2. Contraction**: shows missing letters	*the boy's bag (1 boy) · the boys' bags (many) · the children's toys · don't, it's (= it is), they're*
Colon :	Introduces a list, an explanation or a quotation	*Bring the following: a pen, a ruler and a calculator.*

Semicolon ;	Joins two closely related main clauses (instead of a conjunction); separates long list items that contain commas	*It was late; we went home.*
Inverted commas " "	Direct speech; quotations; titles; words used in a special/sarcastic way	*"Hello," she said. · He called it a "holiday".*
Dash –	A sudden break or added emphasis; extra information	*He opened the door – and screamed.*
Hyphen -	Joins words into one compound; some prefixes; numbers	*well-known, mother-in-law, re-enter, twenty-one*
Brackets ( )	Extra, less important information	*The ANC (African National Congress)...*
Ellipsis ...	Words left out; a pause or suspense; an unfinished thought	*I was going to tell you, but...*
Capital letters	Start of a sentence; proper nouns; "I"; titles; days and months	*On Monday, Ms Daniels and I went to Cape Town.*

> **its vs it's:** **it's** = it is / it has (*It's raining.*); **its** = belonging to it (*The dog wagged its tail.*). Possessive pronouns (its, hers, ours, theirs, yours) **never** have an apostrophe.

3.9 Spelling and plurals

Plural rules

Rule	Examples
Most nouns: add **-s**	book → books, car → cars
Ending in **s, ss, sh, ch, x, z**: add **-es**	bus → buses, class → classes, dish → dishes, church → churches, box → boxes
Consonant + **y**: change y to **i** and add **-es**	baby → babies, city → cities, lady → ladies
Vowel + **y**: just add **-s**	boy → boys, day → days, key → keys
Ending in **f / fe**: usually change to **-ves**	leaf → leaves, knife → knives, wolf → wolves, half → halves, life → lives
Exceptions with f: add **-s**	roof → roofs, chief → chiefs, belief → beliefs, chef → chefs, cliff → cliffs
Consonant + **o**: usually **-es**	potato → potatoes, tomato → tomatoes, hero → heroes, echo → echoes
Exceptions with o: add **-s**	photo → photos, piano → pianos, radio → radios, zoo → zoos, video → videos

Irregular plurals	man → men, woman → women, child → children, foot → feet, tooth → teeth, mouse → mice, goose → geese, person → people, ox → oxen
Same in singular and plural	sheep, deer, fish, series, species, aircraft
Foreign (Latin/Greek) words	cactus → cacti, fungus → fungi, crisis → crises, analysis → analyses, criterion → criteria, phenomenon → phenomena, medium → media, bacterium → bacteria
Compound nouns: make the **main word** plural	mother-in-law → mothers-in-law, passer-by → passers-by, commander-in-chief → commanders-in-chief
Only plural	scissors, trousers, glasses, jeans, news (takes a singular verb)

Spelling rules

Rule	Examples
i before e except after c (when the sound is "ee")	believe, field, piece · receive, ceiling, deceive · exceptions: seize, weird, either, neither
Drop the silent e before a suffix starting with a vowel	make → making, hope → hoping, love → lovable · keep e before a consonant: hope → hopeful, care → careful
Double the final consonant (one vowel + one consonant, stressed syllable) before -ing/-ed/-er	run → running, stop → stopped, big → bigger, begin → beginning · but: open → opening, visit → visited
Consonant + **y** → **i** before a suffix (not before -ing)	happy → happiness, carry → carried · carry → carrying
-ful has one l	beautiful, careful, spoonful
Words with **ll** drop one l in compounds	all + ready → already, all + so → also, well + come → welcome

Commonly misspelt words

- accommodation (double c, double m)
- definitely
- necessary (one c, double s)
- separate
- government
- environment
- embarrass
- occurred
- beginning
- believe
- receive
- tomorrow
- business
- disappear
- immediately
- library
- February
- Wednesday
- restaurant
- argument (no e after u)

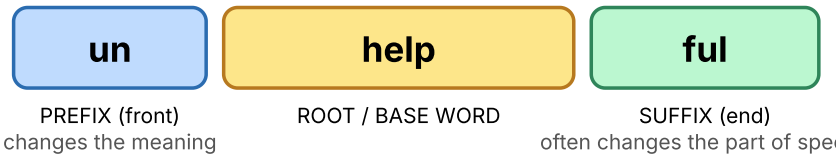
4. Vocabulary

4.1 Synonyms (and antonyms)

Synonyms are words with the **same or nearly the same** meaning. **Antonyms** are words with **opposite** meanings. A synonym must be the **same part of speech** and fit the **context**.

Word	Synonyms	Antonym
happy	joyful, cheerful, content, glad	sad
big	large, huge, enormous, vast	small
brave	courageous, fearless, bold	cowardly
angry	furious, cross, irate, livid	calm
begin	start, commence	end, finish
difficult	hard, challenging, tough	easy
rich	wealthy, affluent, prosperous	poor
clever	intelligent, bright, smart	stupid
ancient	old, antique	modern
generous	giving, unselfish	mean, selfish

4.2 Prefixes and suffixes



un + help + ful = unhelpful

Prefix	Meaning	Example
un-, in-, im-, il-, ir-, dis-, non-	not / opposite	unhappy, incorrect, impossible, illegal, irregular, dislike, non-fiction
mis-	wrongly	misunderstand, misspell
re-	again / back	rewrite, return
pre-	before	preview, prehistoric

Suffix	Forms a...	Example
-ness, -ment, -tion, -sion, -ity, -ship, -hood, -dom	noun	kindness, enjoyment, education, decision, ability, friendship, childhood, freedom
-er, -or, -ist, -ian	noun (person)	teacher, actor, artist, musician
-ful	adjective (full of)	helpful, careful

post-	after	postpone, post-war
sub-	under	submarine, subway
super-	above / more	superhero, supermarket
inter-	between	international, interact
trans-	across	transport, transatlantic
anti-	against	antibiotic, antisocial
auto-	self	autobiography, automatic
bi- / tri-	two / three	bicycle, triangle
over- / under-	too much / too little	overcook, underpaid
ex-	former / out	ex-president, exit

-less	adjective (without)	hopeless, careless
-able, -ible	adjective (can be)	readable, visible
-ous, -ive, -al, -ic, -y	adjective	famous, creative, natural, heroic, sunny
-ly	adverb	quickly, happily
-ise / -ify / -en	verb	realise, simplify, darken

Forming words: *decide (verb) → decision (noun) → decisive (adjective) → decisively (adverb)* · *beauty → beautiful → beautify → beautifully*.

4.3 Homophones and homonyms

Homophones sound the same but have **different spellings and meanings**. **Homonyms** are **spelt the same** (and usually sound the same) but have **different meanings**.

Homophones	
there (place) · **their** (belonging to them) · **they're** (they are)	**your** (belonging to you) · **you're** (you are)
to (direction) · **too** (also / excessively) · **two** (2)	**its** (belonging to it) · **it's** (it is)
whose (belonging to whom) · **who's** (who is)	**where** (place) · **wear** (clothes) · **were** (past of are – not a homophone but often confused)
hear (with ears) · **here** (this place)	**weather** (rain, sun) · **whether** (if)
knew (past of know) · **new** (not old)	**right** (correct) · **write** (with a pen)
break (smash) · **brake** (stop a car)	**peace** (no war) · **piece** (a part)
principal (head of school) · **principle** (a rule/belief)	**stationary** (not moving) · **stationery** (pens, paper)
allowed (permitted) · **aloud** (out loud)	**sea** · **see**; **son** · **sun**; **meat** · **meet**; **bare** · **bear**

Homonym	Meaning 1	Meaning 2
bat	a flying animal	used to hit a ball
bank	where money is kept	the side of a river
bark	sound a dog makes	outer layer of a tree
match	a game	a stick to make fire
left	opposite of right	went away (past of leave)
light	not heavy	brightness from the sun / a lamp
bear	a large animal	to carry / tolerate

Homographs are spelt the same but **pronounced** differently with different meanings: *tear (rip) / tear (from the eye); lead (to guide) / lead (a metal); wind (air) / wind (to turn)*.

4.4 Ambiguity, clichés and redundancy

Ambiguity

A sentence is **ambiguous** when it has **more than one possible meaning**. It is caused by a word with two meanings, an unclear pronoun, or a phrase in the wrong place. To correct it, **rewrite** the sentence so it has only one meaning.

Ambiguous sentence	Why	Corrected
I saw the man with the binoculars.	Who had the binoculars?	**Using binoculars, I saw the man.**
Sipho told Tom that he had won.	Unclear pronoun – who won?	**Sipho told Tom, "You have won."**
For sale: a table for a lady with wooden legs.	Misplaced phrase – who has wooden legs?	**For sale: a table with wooden legs, suitable for a lady.**
Visiting relatives can be boring.	Going to visit them, or relatives who visit?	**It can be boring to visit relatives.**

Ambiguity is sometimes used **on purpose** in adverts, headlines and cartoons to create **humour** (a pun).

Clichés

A **cliché** is an expression that has been used **so often** that it has lost its originality and impact. Good writing avoids clichés.

Cliché	Meaning
at the end of the day	finally / in the end
as old as the hills	very old

avoid it like the plague	stay away from it completely
only time will tell	we will find out later
a piece of cake	very easy
every cloud has a silver lining	something good comes from bad situations
think outside the box	think creatively

Redundancy (tautology)

Redundancy is using **unnecessary words** that repeat the same meaning. **Tautology** is saying the same thing twice in different words. Correct it by **removing** the extra word(s).

Redundant	Correct	Redundant	Correct
free gift	**gift**	*return back*	**return**
past history	**history**	*repeat again*	**repeat**
end result	**result**	*true facts*	**facts**
new innovation	**innovation**	*ATM machine*	**ATM**
unexpected surprise	**surprise**	*7 a.m. in the morning*	**7 a.m.**
two twins	**twins**	*circle around*	**circle**

4.5 Connotation and denotation

Denotation is the **dictionary (literal)** meaning of a word. **Connotation** is the **feeling or idea** the word suggests – positive, negative or neutral.

Word	Denotation	Connotation
home	the place where you live	warmth, safety, family, love
snake	a reptile	a sly, dishonest person (negative)
red	a colour	danger, anger, love, passion
dove	a bird	peace

Positive	Neutral	Negative
slender	thin	skinny
confident	sure of himself	arrogant
thrifty	careful with money	stingy
curious	interested	nosy
youthful	young	childish
determined	firm	stubborn

Writers (especially in adverts and the media) choose words for their **connotation** to influence the reader – this links to **manipulative language** (1.4).

4.6 Formal and informal language

Register is the level of formality of language, chosen to suit the **audience, purpose and situation**.

	Formal	Informal
Used for	Official letters, reports, speeches, essays, job applications, speaking to a principal	Friends, family, chatting, text messages, friendly letters
Features	Full words (no contractions), correct grammar, polite and impersonal, longer sentences, passive voice, advanced vocabulary	Contractions (don't, I'm), slang, abbreviations, personal ("you", "I"), short sentences, exclamation marks, emojis
Examples	*I would like to request information.* · *Please find attached...* · *Dear Sir/Madam*	*Hey, what's up?* · *Gonna chill later.* · *Thanks a mil!*

Informal	Formal	Informal	Formal
kids	children	get	receive / obtain
a lot of	many / a great deal of	ask for	request
find out	discover	help	assist
buy	purchase	start	commence
enough	sufficient	about	approximately

Slang is very informal language used by a particular group (*lekker, sharp-sharp, eish, cool*). **Jargon** is specialised language of a job or field (*medical: diagnosis, prognosis; computers: download, bandwidth*).

4.7 Abbreviations

An **abbreviation** is a **shortened** form of a word or phrase.

Type	Meaning	Examples
Acronym	First letters that are **pronounced as a word**	NASA, SADC, AIDS, SARS, laser, scuba
Initialism	First letters **said letter by letter**	SABC, ANC, BBC, ATM, CEO, DVD, SMS
Contraction	Letters left out, often with an apostrophe	can't, I'll, won't, Mr (Mister), Dr (Doctor), Rd (Road)
Shortened word (clipping)	Part of the word is cut off	photo (photograph), exam (examination), phone (telephone), flu (influenza), maths

Abbreviation	Full form	Abbreviation	Full form
e.g.	for example (exempli gratia)	i.e.	that is (id est)
etc.	and so on (et cetera)	N.B.	note well (nota bene)
a.m. / p.m.	before noon / after noon	P.S.	postscript (written after the letter)
RSVP	please reply (répondez s'il vous plaît)	ASAP	as soon as possible
approx.	approximately	no.	number
Mon., Tue. / Jan., Feb.	days and months	km, kg, cm, ml	units of measurement (no full stop)
SA	South Africa	Ltd / Pty	Limited / Proprietary (companies)